Marching in the National Interest

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India is a rich tapestry of diverse ideas and ideologies that have adorned our civilization. Our history is replete with examples of such diversities —social, economic, cultural and political. Every time a hegemonic force has tried to suppress or throttle these diversities, there has been an upsurge from the grassroots to protect the inherent plurality and cosmopolitanism of India. For example, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj famously fought to protect the unique linguistic, cultural and social characteristics of Maharashtra. This virasat (legacy) is why India is universally hailed as a beacon of the melting-pot analogy.

It is because India once again faces such a threat that I walked with Rahul Gandhi in the Bharat Jodo Yatra, which transcended political boundaries and brought together diverse voices in the national interest. Even though some myopically attacked us for this collaboration (citing apparent ideological differences), it was our shared concerns for the fires engulfing Indian democracy that forged our steely alliance. Because other democratic forces in Maharashtra also felt similarly, we felt it was imperative to keep aside political differences and unite in the interest of the Marathi manoos (people). That was the basis of the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA). The MVA's common minimum programme included farmers' issues, unemployment, health, industry, social justice, women, education, urban development, tourism, art and culture. Under our collective stewardship, Maharashtra emerged as one of the best-performing states during the Covid-19 pandemic. We also showcased robust infrastructural growth, an investment of Rs 6.5 lakh crores, and peace and stability, a stark contrast to the current scenario.